

Agent Factory

Building Digital Full-Time Equivalents (FTEs)

UPDATED: Consultants vs. AI Employees (Build vs. Buy)

The Core Strategic Decision for Agentic AI Automation

Zia Khan | Panaversity | PIAIC

Deep Dive on OpenClaw

Why it's unique?

Uniqueness 1

It's "Headless"

Unlike ChatGPT, which waits for a prompt in a browser, OpenClaw runs in the background (terminal/server).

Uniqueness 2

It's "Permissive"

It connects to real tools immediately (File System, Terminal, Slack/WhatsApp).

Uniqueness 3

The "Employee" Illusion

It feels like an employee because it persists. If you tell it "Monitor this server and fix it if it crashes," it stays awake and does it. A General Agent would time out; a Custom Agent would require you to write the monitoring loop code. OpenClaw provides the runtime for this "employment."

The Core Strategic Decision

Three Paths to Agentic AI Automation



Option A

"Smart Consultant"

General Agents

Claude Code, Cowork, Codex, Goose

Session-based, autonomous reasoning. A senior contractor you bring in for a specific problem.

BUILD



Option B

"Assembly Line"

Custom-Built AI Employees

OpenAI Agents SDK, Google ADK, Claude Agent SDK

You architect every workflow, guardrail, and hand-off. You write the job description and training manual.

BUY



Option C

"Pre-Trained New Hire"

Pre-Built AI Employees

OpenClaw, Manus, Devin (Coding), Harvey (Law)

Pre-packaged, always-on, multi-channel. They come pre-trained; you just onboard them to your systems.

Options B & C are both **Digital FTEs (AI Employees)** — distinguished by the classic **Build vs. Buy** decision

General Agents

Claude Code, Cowork, Codex, Goose

The "Smart Consultant" — You bring them in for a specific problem

Key Features

- ✓ **zero-Shot Planning:** You state the goal; it determines the steps.
- ✓ **Deep Integration:** Accesses local files, git history, and command line directly.
- ✓ **Enhanced by MCP:** Uses "Model Context Protocol" to plug in external systems instantly.
- ✓ **Enhanced by Agent Skills:** Modular capabilities (organized folders with instructions, scripts, and resources).

Best For

- ✓ Complex debugging & coding
- ✓ Ad-hoc analysis (e.g., "Why are sales down in Q3?")
- ✓ Tasks requiring human-like judgment
- ✓ Expensive per task but invaluable for non-routine work

AI Employees: The Build vs. Buy Decision

Both paths produce Digital FTEs — the question is how you create them



BUILD — Custom-Built AI Employees

You are the architect.

You define every guardrail, hand-off, and orchestration step. The AI follows your script precisely.

Like writing a job description, SOPs, and training manual — then hiring a robot to execute them perfectly.



BUY — Pre-Built AI Employees

You are the manager.

They come pre-trained with capabilities. You onboard them to your systems, give them access, and set expectations.

Like hiring a skilled employee who already knows their craft — you just show them where the office is.

Custom-Built AI Employees

BUILD

OpenAI Agents SDK, Google ADK, Claude Agent SDK

The "Assembly Line" — You architect the workflow from scratch

Key Features

- ✓ **Guardrails:** Strict control over what the agent can and cannot do.
- ✓ **Orchestration:** Define exact hand-offs between multiple agents (e.g., Triage Agent → Support Agent).
- ✓ **UI/UX Flexibility:** Can be embedded in web apps, Slack, or internal dashboards.
- ✓ **Enhanced by MCP and Agent Skills:** Plug in external systems and modular capabilities.

Best For

- ✓ Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs)
- ✓ High-volume tasks (e.g., processing 5,000 invoices)
- ✓ Customer-facing interactions (requires strict safety)
- ✓ You are the architect. The AI follows the script.

Pre-Built AI Employees

[BUY](#)

OpenClaw, Manus, Devin (Coding), Harvey (Law)

Devin (Coding), Harvey (Law)

The "Pre-Trained New Hire" — Deploy, configure, and onboard

Key Features

- ✓ **Always-On:** Runs 24/7 on your infrastructure — persistent, proactive, autonomous.
- ✓ **Multi-Channel:** WhatsApp, Telegram, Slack, Discord, Teams — wherever you are.
- ✓ **Persistent Memory:** Remembers context across conversations and sessions.
- ✓ **Skill-Extensible:** 100+ AgentSkills, self-hackable, community-driven plugins.

Best For

- ✓ Personal productivity automation (email, calendar, task management)
- ✓ Cross-platform life/work orchestration from your phone
- ✓ DevOps monitoring, cron jobs, and proactive alerting
- ✓ A pre-trained employee you onboard — not build from scratch

Two Flavors of Pre-Built AI Employees

Option C comes in two varieties — distinguished by scope, not architecture

C₁ HORIZONTAL

General-Purpose AI Employees

They do everything across your life and work

- ✓ **OpenClaw:** Open-source, self-hosted, 150K+ stars, 100+ AgentSkills, multi-channel (WhatsApp, Slack, Telegram)
- ✓ **Manus:** Cloud-based autonomous agent, operates independently across tasks
- ✓ **Lindy AI:** No-code AI employees for email, scheduling, sales, support — prebuilt and ready to deploy

Scope: Wide — personal productivity, cross-platform orchestration, life/work automation

C₂ VERTICAL

Domain-Specific AI Employees

Pre-trained experts in a single professional domain

- ✓ **Devin (Coding):** Autonomous AI software engineer. Tag @Devin in Slack/Linear — it plans, codes, tests, and ships PRs.
- ✓ **Harvey (Law):** AI legal employee used by 50%+ of AmLaw 100. Researches, drafts, and analyzes across 60+ jurisdictions.
- ✓ **Emerging...:** Medicine, accounting, finance, HR — every profession will have its vertical AI employee.

Scope: Deep — mastery of one domain's data, workflows, regulations, and professional standards

Three Paths Compared

Consultants vs. Custom-Built Employees vs. Pre-Built Employees

Dimension	Option A "Smart Consultant"	Option B BUILD Custom-Built AI Employee	Option C BUY Pre-Built AI Employee
Examples	Claude Code, Cowork, Codex, Goose	OpenAI Agents SDK, Google ADK, Claude Agent SDK	OpenClaw, Manus, Devin (Coding), Harvey (Law)
What It Is	Autonomous agent in terminal	Framework for building AI workflows	Pre-packaged AI employee
Your Role	State the goal	Architect the workflow	Configure & onboard
Operational Mode	Session-based, on-demand	Embedded in apps	Always-on, 24/7
Interface	Terminal / CLI	Custom UI / API	WhatsApp, Slack, Telegram
Memory	Per-session context	State managed by developer	Persistent across sessions
Workforce Analogy	Contractor	Custom-trained new hire	Pre-trained new hire
Best For	Complex, novel problems	SOPs, high-volume, compliance	Life/work automation

The Digital FTE Spectrum

How the Three Paths Map to Your Workforce

A

Contractor

B

Custom-Built FTE

C

Pre-Built FTE

B + C = Digital FTEs (AI Employees) — Build vs. Buy

You bring them in for a specific problem.

They reason through it, deliver the result, and leave.

*High cost per task.
High value for novel work.*

You design the workflow. They execute it perfectly.

Strict guardrails. Predictable output. Scales to thousands.

*Low cost per task.
Maximum control.*

You onboard them like a new hire. They show up every day.

Persistent memory, multi-channel presence, proactive behavior.

*Always available.
Fastest time to value.*

When to Use What

A Decision Framework for Agentic AI

Choose A: Consultant

- ✓ The task is novel or ambiguous
- ✓ You need deep code reasoning
- ✓ One-off complex analysis
- ✓ You want the agent to plan its own approach

Choose B: Build

- ✓ You need strict guardrails & compliance
- ✓ Processing thousands of items at scale
- ✓ Customer-facing interactions
- ✓ Predictable, repeatable output is critical

Choose C: Buy

- ✓ You want an always-on assistant fast
- ✓ Cross-platform life/work automation
- ✓ You prefer to configure, not code
- ✓ Persistent memory & proactive action matter

The Future is Hybrid

The most effective agentic organizations won't choose just one path.

General Agents for novel thinking

Custom-Built AI Employees for reliable, high-volume processes

Pre-Built AI Employees for persistent, always-on presence

Together, they form your AI-native workforce — your Digital FTEs.